# LS Adaptation Study #005
# Momotaro / Peach Boy

*Cinematic Folktale Pass - Complete Tapas Proof*

*Prepared for LoreSpinner Writer's Room / Performance Layer Case File*

*Source: "Momotaro, or the Story of the Son of a Peach" from Japanese Fairy Tales.*

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## I. The River Brings What the House Cannot Ask For

Long ago, in a green valley where the river ran clear over stones, an old man and an old woman lived by the work of their hands.

Each morning the old man climbed toward the hills with his sickle and rope, returning at dusk beneath a bundle of grass so large it nearly swallowed him from sight. Each morning the old woman carried the house with her: rice to wash, clothes to scrub, small repairs to make before the sun fell and the fire had to be lit again.

They were not unhappy people. They had learned the quiet discipline of making enough from little. But there was one silence in the house that no sweeping, no cooking, no prayer could fill.

No child had ever called them mother or father.

On the morning the peach came, the country seemed to know before they did. The willows shook out their soft grey tassels along the riverbank. The grass was new and bright, and the breeze touched the old couple as they parted for work with a strange tenderness, as though the day had a secret and could hardly keep from smiling.

The old woman found a good place by the river and set down her basket. One by one she took out the clothes and rubbed them clean against the stones. Beneath the clear water, fish flashed like slivers of moving light.

Then something round and golden bumped against the current.

She looked up.

A peach - enormous, pink-gold, ridiculous in its beauty - came bobbing down the river as if it had been sent with an address on it.

The old woman forgot the laundry. She forgot the ache in her knees. She forgot, for one brief instant, how old she was.

"Ah," she whispered, leaning toward it, "what a peach for my old man."

She stretched out her arm, but the peach drifted just beyond her reach. She searched the bank for a stick. Nothing. If she ran for one, the river would take the peach away.

For a moment she stood there, apron wet to the knees, scolding herself for wanting something so badly at her age.

Then she remembered an old river charm, one her mother had sung when she was a girl.

She clapped her hands softly, keeping time with the current.

"Distant water is bitter. Near water is sweet. Pass by the bitter water. Come into the sweet."

The peach turned.

The old woman stopped breathing.

Again she sang. The peach bobbed closer, nudged by no branch, no eddy she could see. It came straight toward her palms and rested against the stones as gently as a sleeping child.

She lifted it with both hands. It was heavier than it should have been. Warm, too, though the river was cold.

The laundry went back into the basket half washed. The old woman went home with the peach pressed to her chest, walking as quickly as her old legs would allow, laughing once at nothing at all because something in her had become young enough to laugh again.

## II. The Child Inside the Peach

The afternoon lasted forever.

The old woman set the peach in the coolest corner of the house. Then she moved it to the best mat. Then she moved it again, because the light through the door fell upon it as though it were something holy, and she was not sure holy things ought to sit in doorways.

When the old man finally returned at sunset, bent under his bundle of grass and leaning on his sickle like a walking stick, she was waiting before he had even reached the gate.

"Ojiisan!" she called. "Come quickly!"

He peered out from behind the grass on his back. "Has the roof fallen in?"

"No."

"Has the rice burned?"

"No."

"Then why are you using your festival voice?"

She took the bundle from him as if he were a lord returning from war and hurried him to the veranda. He washed his feet, still watching her with tired amusement. Then she brought out the peach.

The old man stared.

His mouth opened, closed, opened again.

"Where," he said at last, "does one buy such a peach?"

"One does not buy such a peach," said the old woman, with great dignity. "One is found by such a peach."

She told him the story: the river, the charm, the turning of the fruit toward her hands. The old man listened. At first he smiled. Then he stopped smiling, because the peach sat between them in the lamplight with the quiet confidence of a guest who had not come by accident.

At last his stomach gave a loud, practical complaint.

"Well," he said, recovering himself. "If Heaven sends a peach, Heaven may mean us to eat it."

He brought out the kitchen knife. The blade had barely touched the peach when the fruit split cleanly in two.

Light spilled from the seam.

The old couple fell backward onto the mats.

From inside the peach, a child stepped out.

He was small, perfect, and entirely unafraid. His eyes were bright. His voice, when he spoke, filled the room like a bell struck gently.

"Do not be frightened," said the child. "I am neither demon nor trickster. Heaven heard the sorrow of this house and sent me to be the son of your old age."

The old woman made a sound that was half sob, half laugh. The old man reached for the child, then pulled his hands back, afraid he might vanish if touched.

The child stepped into his arms instead.

After that, there was no more question of fear.

The old woman held him. Then the old man held him. Then they held him together, the three of them gathered around the opened peach while the last daylight faded from the floor.

They named him Momotaro, Son of the Peach.

That night the house was not quiet.

## III. The Request

Momotaro grew as children in folktales grow: quickly, beautifully, and with the sense that the world had been waiting for him to stand upright.

By fifteen he was taller and stronger than the boys of the village. He could lift what grown men dragged. He could split firewood with a single blow. But strength was not what made people lower their voices when he passed. It was the stillness in him. The way he listened before he moved. The way his smile was kind, but his eyes had already measured the road beyond the hill.

The old couple loved him with the anxious gratitude of people who had received a miracle and knew miracles were not possessions.

One morning Momotaro knelt before his foster-father while the old woman worked near the hearth, pretending not to listen.

"Father," he said, "you and Mother have given me more than food and shelter. Your kindness has been higher than the grasses you cut and deeper than the river where Mother washes. I do not know how to repay it."

The old man shifted, uncomfortable with gratitude so formal from the boy whose muddy sandals he still remembered leaving by the door.

"A father raises his son," he said. "A son later cares for his parents. That is the shape of things. There is no debt."

"Then grant me this," Momotaro said. "Let me leave today."

The old woman stopped moving.

The old man stared at him. "Leave?"

"Only for a while."

"Where would you go?"

Momotaro lifted his head. The boy was still there. So was something older.

"To the northeast sea. There is an island beyond it where the oni keep their stronghold. They raid the villages, steal from the people, carry away the innocent, and spill blood as if the world were made for their appetite. They have dishonored this land long enough. I will go there, defeat them, and bring back what they have stolen."

The house listened with them.

The old woman turned away, but not before Momotaro saw her hand close hard around the cloth she had been folding.

The old man looked at the son Heaven had sent him and understood two things at once: that he wished to forbid it, and that he had no right.

"You are not like other boys," he said slowly.

"No," Momotaro answered. Not proudly. Simply.

"Then go," said the old man. His voice broke on the word and repaired itself. "Go as soon as you must. Defeat the oni. Bring peace home with you."

The old woman rose and went to the mortar.

No one asked what she was doing. They all knew.

She pounded rice for kibi dango, millet dumplings for the road. Her eyes were wet, but her hands were steady. If her son was going to war, he would not go hungry.

When the dumplings were ready, she wrapped them carefully and placed them in his bag as if each one were a prayer made round enough to hold.

At the gate, the old couple stood side by side.

"Go with care," they said. "Return victorious."

Momotaro bowed deeply.

"Take care of yourselves until I come home."

Then he turned before he could see them weep and walked toward the road.

## IV. The Dog Who Demanded Tribute

By midday, the road was hot and empty. Momotaro sat beneath a tree and opened the bag of kibi dango. The smell rose warm and sweet, carrying his mother with it.

He had taken one bite when the grass ahead split open and a dog burst out.

It was a great dog, nearly the size of a colt, all bristling fur and bad manners. It planted itself in the road and showed its teeth.

"You pass through my field without permission," the dog growled. "Give me every dumpling in that bag, and I may let you live."

Momotaro looked at the dog. Then at the dumpling in his hand. Then back at the dog.

He laughed.

Not loudly. That would have been rude. But enough.

"You have chosen a poor road for robbery," he said. "I am Momotaro, and I am on my way to the island of the oni. Stand aside, or I will cut you in two from head to tail."

The dog's ears dropped.

His tail vanished between his legs so completely it seemed to leave the story.

He lowered himself until his forehead touched the dust.

"Momotaro? The Momotaro? I have heard of your strength. I did not know. Please forgive my stupidity. If you will accept a rude dog into your service, I will follow you to the oni island and bite whatever must be bitten."

Momotaro considered him. The dog was rude, greedy, and honest about both. These were not the worst qualities in war.

"You may come," Momotaro said.

The dog lifted his head just enough to look hopeful. "And the dumplings?"

Momotaro broke one in half.

"Half," he said. "This is the best kibi dango in Japan. A whole one is for those who ask before threatening murder."

The dog accepted the half with enormous gratitude and no visible shame.

Together, they continued down the road.

## V. The Monkey and the Pheasant

They had crossed two hills and a valley when a monkey dropped from a branch ahead of them, landing lightly in the path as if the tree had bowed him into the road.

"Good morning, Momotaro," said the monkey. "I have heard of your expedition. I would like to go with you."

The dog snapped before Momotaro could answer.

"He already has a dog. What use is a monkey against oni? Climb a tree and applaud from there."

The monkey bared his teeth. "Better to climb than bark at fields you do not own."

They collided in a burst of fur, dust, teeth, and opinions.

Momotaro stepped between them, caught the dog by the scruff and the monkey by the back of his collar, and held them apart as if separating two badly behaved festival drums.

"Enough."

The word was not loud. It did not need to be.

Both animals went still.

Momotaro looked at the monkey. "Who are you?"

"A monkey of these hills. Quick hands, quicker feet. I can climb where dogs fall and steal keys from under sleeping noses. If the oni have walls, you will want me."

The dog made a sound.

Momotaro did not look at him. "I admire useful courage. You may come."

He gave the monkey half a dumpling.

The monkey took it with a flourish. The dog watched this transaction as if witnessing the decline of civilization.

By afternoon the road opened into a broad field. There, a pheasant swept down from the sky and landed before them, scarlet crest bright as a flame. Its feathers carried five colors, and it moved with the offended elegance of a nobleman whose appointment had been delayed.

The dog immediately lunged.

The pheasant leapt, struck out with its spurs, and attacked the dog's tail with such precision that the dog yelped more in outrage than pain.

This time Momotaro let the fight go on for three breaths. He watched the pheasant slash, wheel, and rise again, impossible to catch.

"Good," he said.

The dog paused mid-growl. "Good?"

"Very good."

Momotaro turned to the pheasant. "You have spirit. Surrender now and join us, or I will let the dog continue making a fool of himself until one of you is too tired to walk."

The pheasant folded its wings, head high.

"I am a pheasant of the fields. I apologize for striking your servant. I did not see you, Momotaro. If you will have me, I will fly ahead, scout the walls, and blind the eyes that look down on you."

"Then you will come."

The dog opened his mouth.

Momotaro raised one hand.

The dog shut it again.

Momotaro stood in the road with the dog, monkey, and pheasant before him.

"Listen well. An army that fights itself has already served its enemy. From this moment, you are not dog, monkey, and pheasant competing for my favor. You are my companions. The first one to begin a quarrel goes home."

The dog looked at the monkey. The monkey looked at the pheasant. The pheasant looked at everyone as though already disappointed.

Then all three bowed.

Momotaro divided another dumpling.

After that, they still disliked one another from time to time. But they marched.

## VI. The Sea and the Island

Day after day they hurried north and east, over hills, through valleys, past villages that locked their doors at the word oni and mothers who pulled children close when they heard where Momotaro was going.

At last they came to the sea.

The three animals stopped.

The dog stared at the waves as if the earth had made a mistake.

The monkey climbed onto a rock, then climbed down again when the rock proved too close to the water.

The pheasant, who had been very proud of wings until now, watched the horizon with unusual silence.

Momotaro let them look.

The sea rolled endlessly before them. No bridge. No road. Only water moving under sky.

"Well?" he said at last.

No one answered.

"Afraid of the sea?"

The dog stiffened. "No."

"Then step in."

The dog looked at the water. The water looked back.

Momotaro's voice hardened. "I cannot take cowards to face oni. If this is where your courage ends, this is where your journey ends. I will go alone."

All three rushed him at once.

"No!" cried the monkey.

"We came this far!" said the dog.

"It would be inhuman to abandon us," said the pheasant, which was a strange but effective argument from a bird.

Momotaro studied them until their panic became determination.

Then he nodded.

"Good. Fear is not failure. Turning back because of fear is failure."

They found a small boat. The wind favored them, and the sail filled like a chest taking courage. At first the dog crouched low and growled at every wave. The monkey clung to the mast and accused the boat of bad character. The pheasant stood at the bow, pretending not to be alarmed by anything beneath the dignity of sky-born creatures.

By the second day, they were telling stories of their own greatness.

By the third, the dog and monkey were arguing over whose story had been more useful to the morale of the crew.

By the fourth, even the pheasant laughed.

Momotaro watched them from the stern and found, to his surprise, that the voyage felt less long because they were foolish together.

Then land rose from the sea.

A black island. High cliffs. Iron gates above them. A castle crouched on the heights like a beast that had learned architecture.

Momotaro stood.

The animals fell silent.

"There," he said. "Oni Island."

## VII. The Raid on the Oni Castle

Momotaro called the pheasant to him.

"Your wings are our first advantage. Fly to the castle. Challenge them. Draw their eyes upward."

The pheasant's crest lifted. At last, a task worthy of presentation.

It sprang into the air and flew toward the castle, beating its wings with such force that sunlight flashed through the feathers.

It landed on the roof above the courtyard and cried out:

"Oni of this island! Momotaro has come. Break off your horns and surrender, or we will take your stronghold by force."

For one stunned heartbeat, the oni only stared.

Then they laughed.

They were huge, horned, red-haired creatures with iron clubs and tiger-skin trousers, and their laughter shook dust from the roof tiles.

"A pheasant commands us?" one roared.

"A garnish threatens the feast!" cried another.

They seized their iron bars and swung at the bird. The pheasant lifted away from each blow, then struck back at eyes, ears, horns, and pride. It wheeled so quickly above them that the oni began shouting at shadows, convinced there must be ten birds, then twenty.

While they raged at the sky, Momotaro brought the boat to shore.

The cliff path was narrow. The castle wall above was nearly sheer. But by a stream at the base of the rock, Momotaro saw two young women washing clothes stained dark with blood.

Their hands moved mechanically. Their faces were hollow with exhaustion.

Momotaro approached carefully, lowering his sword.

"Who has done this to you?"

The women looked at him and, for a moment, hope frightened them more than despair.

"We are captives of the Demon King," one whispered. "Taken from our homes. Daughters of daimyo, made servants here. One day he will kill us and eat us, as he has eaten others."

The second woman gripped the wet cloth so tightly water ran between her fingers like tears.

Momotaro's face did not change. But the dog felt the air around him go cold.

"Show me the way in," Momotaro said.

They led him to a low back gate, so small that even Momotaro had to turn his shoulders to pass through. The monkey slipped in first, delighted to have been proven necessary. He lifted the latch from within. The dog squeezed after him, furious at the indignity. Momotaro entered last.

Above them, the pheasant saw the gate open and screamed in triumph.

Then the raid began.

The pheasant drove the oni down from the roof. The monkey went where hands were needed: latches, chains, ropes, locks. The dog struck low and hard, dragging giants off balance. Momotaro moved through the courtyard like a storm given a human shape.

The oni fought with iron bars. They roared. They broke stones. They slammed their clubs into the earth hard enough to split it.

But they had ruled by terror for so long they had forgotten what courage looks like from the other side.

One by one they fell back. Some tumbled from the parapet to the rocks below. Some fled toward the sea and were driven into it. Some threw down their clubs and covered their horns with shaking hands.

At last only the Oni Chief remained.

He was larger than all the others, with horns like blackened branches and a club heavy enough to crush a gate. But when he saw Momotaro standing before him, sword bright, companions at his side, prisoners watching from the shadows, the chief understood what the castle had understood too late.

This was not a boy who had come to test himself.

This was judgment.

The Oni Chief dropped his iron bar.

He knelt.

With both hands, he broke the horns from his head and laid them at Momotaro's feet.

"Spare me," he said. "Take the treasure. Take all of it. Only spare my life."

Momotaro looked at him for a long moment.

"You ask for mercy because you have lost," he said. "The people you stole from asked before that. You did not hear them."

The chief lowered his head.

Momotaro bound him and gave him into the monkey's charge. The monkey accepted this responsibility with the alarming satisfaction of someone who had many ideas about knots.

## VIII. The Return

The castle gates opened from the inside.

Out came the prisoners: daughters of lords, sons of farmers, merchants, servants, children who had forgotten the smell of their own homes. Some carried bundles. Some carried nothing. All of them stopped at the threshold and looked at the sea as if they had never expected it to belong to the world again.

Momotaro gathered the stolen treasure, not as spoils, but as witness. Gold, cloth, swords, coins, heirlooms, all the bright things taken from frightened houses and hidden behind oni walls.

The dog carried what he could. The monkey carried more than he should have been able to. The pheasant flew above the boat, crying the news ahead to any coastline that would listen.

Momotaro returned home with the rescued captives, the captured Oni Chief, and the treasure that had been stolen from the land.

Villages came out to meet him. First one, then another, until the road itself seemed lined with people. They called him hero. They bowed. They laughed and wept in the same breath.

Momotaro accepted their thanks with the solemnity of someone who knew victory was not the same as joy, though it often wore joy's face on the road home.

At last he reached the small house in the valley.

The old woman was at the gate before he could call out.

The old man came after her, slower, pretending dignity when what he wanted was to run.

Momotaro bowed to them.

For a terrible second, all three were too full to move.

Then the old woman crossed the distance and struck him once on the arm.

"You took too long," she said, and began to cry.

The old man put both hands on Momotaro's shoulders. He looked at the son the peach had brought them, the son who had gone to face oni and returned with peace behind him.

"You came home," he said.

"I said I would," Momotaro answered.

The treasure he brought allowed the old couple to live in comfort all their remaining days. The captives returned to their families. The oni no longer terrorized the land. The dog, monkey, and pheasant were remembered as companions of great courage, though each privately believed the story would have ended poorly without his own particular contribution.

And in the valley, when the river ran bright in summer and the willows shook out their tassels, people still told the story of the old woman who sang to a peach, and the child who came from it, and the house that was quiet no more.

## Writer's Room Notes

**Why the whole-story pass matters**: Momotaro is short enough to complete in one sitting, which makes it an ideal tapas proof. The pass preserves the complete source arc instead of stretching it into a bigger system.

**Modern without flattening**: The language is more immediate and scene-forward than the source translation, but the structure remains recognizably Momotaro: peach miracle, heavenly child, foster parents, kibi dango, companions, oni island, rescue, return.

**Performance targets**: The old woman gains longing and comic eagerness. The old man gains warmth and practicality. Momotaro gains solemn purpose without becoming a generic action hero. Dog, monkey, and pheasant become distinct performance engines. The oni become frightening but still folktale-clear.

**Tapas proof**: The story does not need a deep multi-session tracker to work. It needs emotional density, clear scene turns, a few memorable characters, and a complete aftertaste.

**Cultural handling**: This pass uses only a few culturally specific terms where they carry meaning: Momotaro, kibi dango, oni, daimyo, ojiisan. The goal is not to explain Japan to the user, but to let the story remain Japanese while becoming more legible to a modern reader.

**Future LS adaptation possibility**: If converted to interactive form, the likely playable loop would focus on: how the old woman calls the peach, how Momotaro says goodbye, how he handles each companion, how he keeps the party unified, and how the raid is approached. This should remain tapas-sized unless deliberately expanded into a larger folktale world.

## Case File Additions

- Public-domain international stories may not need to be culturally familiar to American users if the Performance Layer makes the emotional engine immediately legible.
- A very short source can be an advantage, not a limitation, when the goal is tapas: high-density, complete, memorable, and low-friction.
- The Performance Layer must protect cultural soul while modernizing friction. Modern pacing should not mean Westernizing the story.
- Folktales need character density too. A simple tale becomes more playable when archetypes become performable without losing their archetypal clarity.
- For tapas, completion is part of the reward. The user should leave with a full story in their hands, not a partial system.

## Working Principle

**A tapas story does not need to become larger to become alive.**

*It needs enough performance, emotion, and movement to feel complete.*